2.4 Creative Expression

In every civilization, writers and artists ask important questions and help shape and define culture and identity. In the 19th century, American literature and art exploded with creativity.

MAIN IDEA Nineteenth-century American writers and artists helped define what it means to be an American.

AMERICAN AUTHORS ON THE RISE

As reformers advocated for solutions to social problems, writers in the 19th century set out to shape the American identity. Some used the events of American history as their setting. Others reflected social and intellectual movements.

Washington Irving's 1820 story "Rip Van Winkle" was a comment on the dramatic change the American Revolution had brought about. **Henry Wadsworth Longfellow's** poem "Paul Revere's Ride" created an American legend by fictionalizing and bringing to life one of the most exciting events of the Revolution. **James Fenimore Cooper** wrote the first American novel in 1823. *The Pioneers* described life for ordinary Americans on the New York frontier in the late 1700s, before the nation began its westward expansion.

Some 19th-century authors wrote about conflict and individualism. **Nathaniel Hawthorne** wrote during the mid-1800s, but his novel, *The Scarlet Letter,* focused on love and guilt among the Puritans of Massachusetts in the 1640s. **Herman Melville's** *Moby Dick* told the story of Captain Ahab pursuing the great white whale. The novel was Melville's allegory for Americans' reckless westward expansion and obsession with wealth.

One especially rich source of inspiration for some 19th-century writers was **transcendentalism**, an intellectual and social movement of the mid-1800s led by **Ralph Waldo Emerson**. The movement's goal was to transcend, or rise above, the expectations society placed on people. Transcendentalists thought that people should be self-reliant and connected to the natural world. Emerson's book *Nature* reflected these values.

Walt Whitman first published *Leaves of Grass* in 1855. One of the best-known poems in the collection is "Song of Myself," Whitman's celebration of individualism.

PRIMARY SOURCE

I CELEBRATE myself, and sing myself,
And what I assume you shall assume,
For every atom belonging to me as good
belongs to you.
. . .
I too am not a bit tamed, I too am
untranslatable,
I sound my barbaric yawp over the roofs of
the world.

—from "Song of Myself," by Walt Whitman, 1855

One of Emerson's students, **Henry David Thoreau**, lived alone in a simple cabin by Walden Pond for 26 months to write his memoir, *Walden*. **Louisa May Alcott**, the daughter of Bronson Alcott, a transcendentalist, grew up in the company of Emerson and Thoreau. Alcott wrote about family relationships and growing up as a female in the 19th century—the focus of her most successful work, *Little Women*.

Walt Whitman and **Emily Dickinson** forged new paths in poetry by breaking traditional rules. Poetry of the period was flowery and romantic, but Whitman and Dickinson wrote honestly and directly. In his most important work, *Leaves of Grass*, Whitman used free verse, or poetry that

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doesn't rhyme or depend upon a strict meter. Emily Dickinson also wrote poems that ignored established rules about rhyme and rhythm. She shared them with so few people that even her family members were not aware of all her poems until after her death.

Transcendentalists supported women's rights, abolition, and other social reforms. Organized religion, restrictive laws and social institutions, and industrialization inhibited individuals from fully expressing themselves. Certain authors gave a voice to those who were sometimes overlooked. Whitman, for example, wrote openly about love as well as same-sex relationships. His work also celebrated laborers, immigrants, and people who were all part of the growing diversity of the nation.

PAINTING AMERICAN BEAUTY

Nineteenth-century visual artists also shaped American identity through landscape paintings that celebrated the diverse beauty of the United States. **Thomas Cole** was one of the early leaders of an art movement known as the **Hudson River School**. In the 1820s, Cole hiked in New York's Catskill Mountains and painted magnificent scenes of the Hudson River Valley. Hudson River School painters became known for their landscapes, which often highlighted people's relationship with nature.

Asher B. Durand and **Frederic Edwin Church**, friends of Cole, were two artists to emerge from the Hudson River School. Cole inspired Durand to switch from painting portraits to painting landscapes. Church painted natural phenomena such as waterfalls, volcanoes, icebergs, and rainbows. A German immigrant and artist named **Albert Bierstadt** painted panoramic scenes of the Rocky Mountains, the Grand Canyon, and the Yosemite Valley using Hudson River School styles.

Crystal Bridges Museum of American Art, Bentonville, Arkansas

In 1848, Asher B. Durand completed *Kindred Spirits,* which he painted as a tribute to the friendship of painter Thomas Cole and poet William Cullen Bryant. The two artists are overlooking Fawns Leap and the Kaaterskill Falls—two sites in the Catskill Mountains of New York that cannot actually be viewed at the same time. Throughout their artistic lives, all three men—Durand, Cole, and Bryant—used the beauty of nature as their inspiration.



CRITICAL VIEWING Why might Durand have created a scene that brought two separate sites together?

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What historical events influenced American literature and art in the 19th century?
2. **DESCRIBE** In what ways did common themes in artistic expression reveal the ideals and aspirations of the new nation?
3. **SYNTHESIZE** How did writers, visual artists, and transcendental thinkers shape American identity in the 19th century?

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